



DATA ACTIVISM AGAINST FEMINICIDE



Data Activism Against Femicide

© Data Against Femicide – Latin America, Caribbean and Beyond

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Feminicidio
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DATA
CULTURE
GROUP



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INTRODUCTION

We are delighted to share this report, which reflects five years of collective work resulting from the Data Against Femicide (*Datos Contra el Femicidio*, DCF) project. Data Against Femicide is a South-North participatory action research and design project that supports the work of activists and civil society organizations that produce data on gender-related violence and its most lethal expression: femicide. **The project has three main objectives:**

1.

To understand the practices, strategies, and challenges involved in data activism against femicide in different contexts.

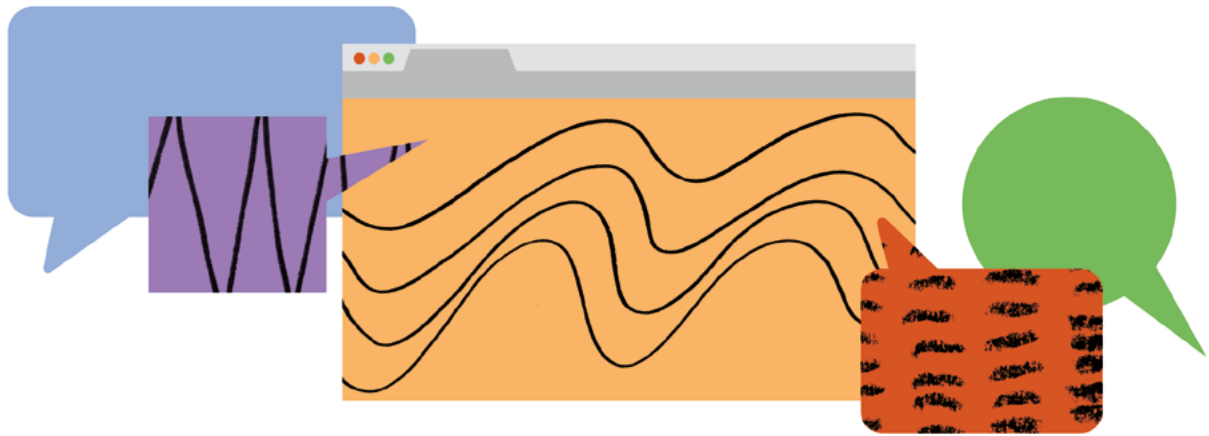
2.

To foster an international community of practice around the production of data on femicide.

3.

To co-design and develop technological tools to support data production and communication about femicide.

DATA ACTIVISM AGAINST FEMICIDE



These goals were outlined in 2019, when the project began as a collaboration between Catherine D'Ignazio (Data + Feminism Lab, MIT), Silvana Fumega (Independent Consultant), and Helena Suárez Val (Feminicidio Uruguay). In 2023, Isadora Cruxên (Queen Mary University of London) joined the leadership team. Since its inception, the project has benefited from the contributions of a broad and diverse team of research affiliates, students, and partner organizations and projects, such as the Latin American Open Data Initiative (ILDA), the Data Culture Project (Northeastern University) and Media Cloud. We highlight all of the contributors at the end of this report.

This report distills the main results and insights we have learned from the project over the last few years, from collective and individual publications as well as from collaborative discussion spaces. It is important to underscore that our purpose is to support existing data production practices led by activists and civil society organizations. This means that the project does not seek to understand the causes of feminicidal violence in different contexts, nor does it produce its own data or systematize others' data on feminicides. We understand this to be the role of the activists and groups themselves, who are the ones who have deep contextual knowledge about this violence in their territories.

In this report, we bring together questions and concepts that have informed our work, share what we have learned about data activism against femicide in various contexts, particularly in Latin America and North America, and present the technological tools we have developed in collaboration with diverse activists to support the production of data on femicide. We also reflect on this work in relation to the urgent public debate around the development of artificial intelligence (AI) and concerns about datafication and data extractivism, highlighting the importance of feminist perspectives in the production of data as well as in the creation and deployment of technologies that address structural inequalities and embrace plural experiences of being, living, and fighting against injustices.

We share this report with the aim of continuing to contribute to collective conversations on the role of feminist data activism and feminist technologies in knowledge building, advocacy and political mobilization against gender-related violence and femicide.

FEMINICIDE AND DATA ACTIVISM

HOW DO WE UNDERSTAND FEMINICIDE?

Femicide can broadly be understood as the murder of women and girls, cisgender or transgender, for reasons relating to their gender. Its definition and scope vary according to context. Legislation in different countries or regions – when it exists – tends to define it differently (see box). Activists who monitor femicides may also work with different conceptualisations, as we will discuss later.

Within the DCF project, we follow the concept of femicide proposed by Rosa-Linda Fregoso and Cynthia Bejarano⁰¹, who explain femicide as a form of violence motivated both by gender subordination and by the intersection of gender dynamics with the cruelties of racism and economic injustices in local as well as global contexts. In this sense, we join many activists and scholars who work with an *intersectional* or *transversal* conception of femicide. This means that we situate this form of violence in relation to processes of gender subordination that are deeply linked to racial inequalities, forms of economic violence, historical processes of colonial dispossession, and other structural forms of oppression.

LEGAL FORMULATIONS RELATED TO FEMINICIDE

Responding to longstanding demands from feminist and women's movements against gender-related violence, 18 countries in Latin America have developed legislation criminalizing femicide/feminicide in the last two decades. However, laws differ substantially across countries⁰².

In the Caribbean and North America, there is a lack of legal definitions and protections for women's right to life and security. For example, as highlighted in *Counting Femicide*, the United States and Canada still do not have specific laws addressing femicide but are making legal advancements in areas such as intimate partner violence and Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls (MMIWG2).

In the United States, the Violence Against Women Act (VAWA) establishes provisions for services and programs to prevent various forms of gender-related violence even if it does not define femicide as a distinct crime or recognize the murder of women as a violation of their civil rights.

⁰¹ Fregoso, Rosa-Linda and Bejarano, Cynthia. (2010). *Terrorizing Women: Femicide in the Americas*. Duke University Press, p. 5.

⁰² Deus, Alicia and Diana González. (2018) "Análisis de legislación sobre femicidio/feminicidio en América Latina y el Caribe e insumos para una ley modelo." ONU Mujeres. Panamá: Casa de las Naciones Unidas.

WHAT ABOUT DATA ACTIVISM?

Around the world, there are many initiatives that seek to document and produce data on cases of femicide and other gender-related violence in different contexts. As part of our project, we have cataloged more than 190 such efforts globally. These initiatives are carried out both by individuals and civil society organizations. Some are more institutionalized than others, and many are undertaken on an unpaid basis.

The initiatives have diverse motivations, but they tend to share the desire to:

Demonstrate how gender-related violence and femicide are structural problems that tend to be rendered invisible in everyday life.

Memorialize the lives of murdered women and girls.

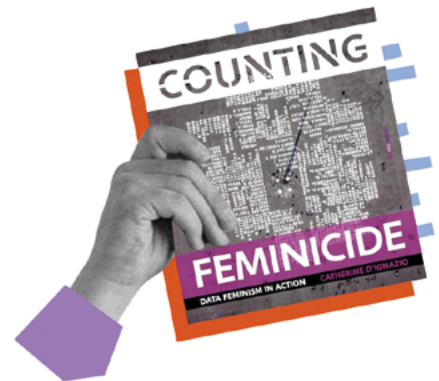
Support social mobilization and political advocacy to combat gender-related violence.

Develop counter-narratives that problematize media coverage of femicide, which often blames or re-victimizes women and girls.

Draw attention to the limitations of official public records and data, which tend to be incomplete, poorly documented, or non-existent.

Although these initiatives do not necessarily identify themselves as such, we can understand them as forms of **data activism**, that is, as ways of producing and using data with the aim of promoting social change, supporting political strategies, and building new forms of collective action⁰³.

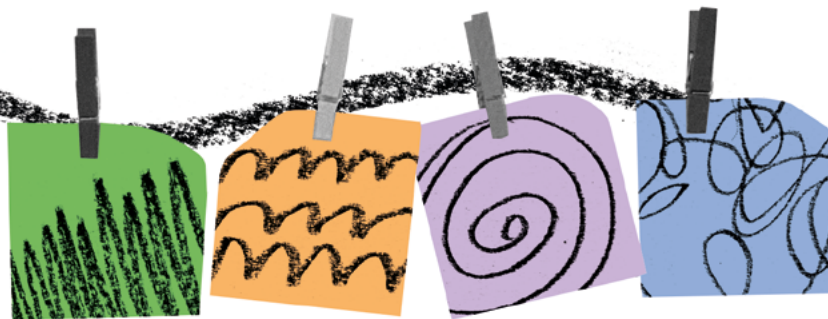
Data activism practices against femicide also contribute to constructing alternative forms of data production centered on context, care, memory, and socioeconomic justice. In her book *Counting Femicide*⁰⁴, Catherine D'Ignazio positions these practices as part of a **restorative/transformational data science**. **Restorative** because it is oriented to restoring rights, dignity, life, living and vitality to individuals, families, communities, and the general public harmed by structural inequalities. **Transformational** because it works to dismantle and change the structural conditions that result in various forms of oppression, exclusion, and violence.



⁰³ Here we rely on the definition of data activism proposed by Milan and Gutierrez. See Milan, Stefania and Gutierrez, Miren. (2018). Technopolitics in the Age of Big Data: The Rise of Proactive Data Activism in Latin America. In: Sierra Caballero, F. and Gravante, T. (eds.). *Networks, Movements and Technopolitics in Latin America*. Springer International Publishing.

⁰⁴ D'Ignazio, Catherine. (2024). *Counting Femicide: Data Feminism in Action*. MIT Press Open.

KEY CONCEPTS



DATA FEMINISM

Inspired by intersectional feminist thought, *data feminism* seeks to make visible and confront power asymmetries in the production, analysis, and circulation of data, as well as to devise strategies that put data science in the service of justice and social transformation. Catherine D'Ignazio and Lauren Klein⁰⁵ propose **seven principles** to guide a feminist perspective on data: examine power, challenge power, elevate emotion and embodiment, rethink binaries and hierarchies, embrace pluralism, consider context, and make labor visible.

MISSING DATA

When data do not exist, are poorly collected, poorly maintained or updated, difficult to access, or purposefully removed, this can be understood as *missing data*: information that is not properly produced or shared by institutions that have the power to do so⁰⁶. In the experience of several activists and organizations we have spoken to or worked with, much of the official data on femicide produced by public institutions – when it exists – falls into this category. One of the main problems is underreporting, which leads to official numbers that underestimate the reality of femicide violence.

COUNTERDATA

When there is a lack of data about a social problem or phenomenon, civil society actors – such as political activists, academics, journalists, NGOs, or social movements – may produce their own data. This is part of what we call *counterdata* production, a form of data activism that involves collecting, recording, interpreting, and using data to challenge official or hegemonic information and narratives. The production of counterdata is intentional, contextualized, and political.

STRATEGIC DATAFICATION

Acknowledging that data can also be and has been used to oppress, exclude, and discriminate, activist and researcher Helena Suárez Val, one of the coordinators of the Data Against Femicide project, has put forth the concept of *strategic datafication* to describe the possibilities for activists to mobilize data in careful and strategic ways, while also recognizing the limits of data⁰⁷.

⁰⁵ D'Ignazio, Catherine y Klein, Lauren F. (2020). *Data feminism*. MIT press.

⁰⁶ Jungs de Almeida, Alessandra, Klein, Lauren and D'Ignazio, Catherine. (2024). Missing Data. In: Singh, R., Burrell, J., Davison, P. (eds.). *Keywords of the Datafied State*. Data & Society.

⁰⁷ Suárez Val, Helena. "*Strategic datafication*". To be published soon.

METHODOLOGICAL APPROACH

Based on the principles of data feminism, our project seeks to understand and support data activism against feminicide from a participatory and plural approach that centers the lived experiences, practices, and goals of activists and organizations that produce counterdata in different contexts. We draw on a combination of methods to support our objectives.

WHAT HAVE WE DONE?

We cataloged more than 190 initiatives around the world that produce data on some form of lethal gender-related violence.

We have conducted semi-structured qualitative interviews with over 40 activists, journalists and civil society groups monitoring some form of feminicide in 18 countries, mostly in Latin America. We focused on Latin America partially because of our team's research and advocacy interests and experiences, and partially because of the historical strength of Latin American feminist movements in confronting gender-related violence and feminicide.

To complement the qualitative interviews, we conducted a *global survey* of data activists on feminicide: 129 groups responded to at least part of the questionnaire and 38 completed it.

In collaboration with activists and partner organizations from different countries, we conducted participatory processes of co-design, co-development and testing of artificial intelligence (AI) tools to support feminicide data activism in Spanish, English and Portuguese, and we are now developing a Swahili version.

We hold annual events and workshops to create spaces for dialogue, knowledge sharing, and solidarity building around data activism on feminicide.

Coordinadora Nacional de Mujeres Indígenas - CONAMI
(Emergencia Comunitaria de Género)

Ellas Tienen Nombre

Letra Ese (Homicidios de personas LGBT+ en México)

Anonymous organization

Yo te nombro: El mapa de los feminicidios en México

Departamento de Estudios Culturales, Dirección General Regional
Noroeste, El Colegio de la Frontera Norte. (Base de datos del feminicidio
en Ciudad Juárez (personal research file of Julia E. Monárrez Frago).

Grupo Guatemalteco de Mujeres (Muertes Violentas de
Mujeres y Femicidios en Guatemala)

ORMUSA (Observatorio de violencia contra las mujeres)

Recordar-LAS

Red Feminista Antimilitarista (Observatorio
Feminicidios Colombia)

Colombia Diversa (Sin Violencia LGBT)

Alianza Feminista para el Mapeo de
los Femi(ni)cidios en Ecuador

Movimiento Manuela Ramos (El registro de
los feminicidios cometidos en el Perú)

♥ ¿Cuántas Más?

Red Chilena contra la Violencia hacia las Mujeres

Native Women's Association of
Canada (Safe Passages)
Canadian Femicide Observatory
for Justice and Accountability



Sovereign Bodies Institute - SBI (MMIP Database) ✓

Justice for Native People

Jane Doe (Massachusetts Domestic Violence Homicide)

African American Policy Forum (#SayHerName) ✓

Women Count USA ✓

Black Femicide US ✓

Feminicidio.net (Listado De Femicidios y Otros Asesinatos de Mujeres en España)

Observatorio de Equidad de Género Puerto Rico (Monitoreo de feminicidios y desapariciones de mujeres, niñas y personas LGBTQI+)
Seguimiento de Casos PR

Utopix (Observatorio de Femicidios)

Néias - Observatório de Femicídios Londrina ✓

Fórum Cearense de Mulheres ✓

data_labe (Transdados)

Campanha Levante Feminista contra o Femicídio, Transfemicídio e Lesbocídio (Lupa Feminista contra o Femicídio) ✓

NE10 (Uma por Uma)

Laboratório de Estudos de Femicídios ✓

Grupo de Trabalho sobre Femicídio na Bahia ✓

Feminicidio Uruguay ✓

Observatorio Nacional MuMaLá (Observatorio Nacional MuMaLá: Mujeres, Disidencias, Derechos) ✓

Mujeres de Negro Rosario ✓

Ahora que sí nos ven (Observatorio de violencias de género)

La Casa del Encuentro (Observatorio Adriana Marisel Zambrano)

Agencia Presentes (Mapa Periodístico Crímenes de Odio Contra LGBT+)

Mundo Sur (Mapa Latinoamericano de Femicidios, Monitor de Crímenes de Odio LGBTTTIQ+ Marielle Franco)

KEY

6+ GROUPS INTERVIEWED

3-5 GROUPS INTERVIEWED

1-2 GROUPS INTERVIEWED

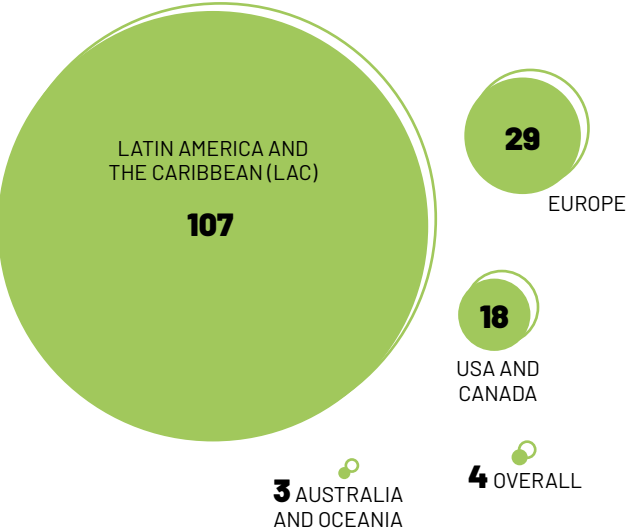
COLLABORATOR

PRODUCING DATA AGAINST FEMINICIDE: ACTIVIST PRACTICES AND STRATEGIES

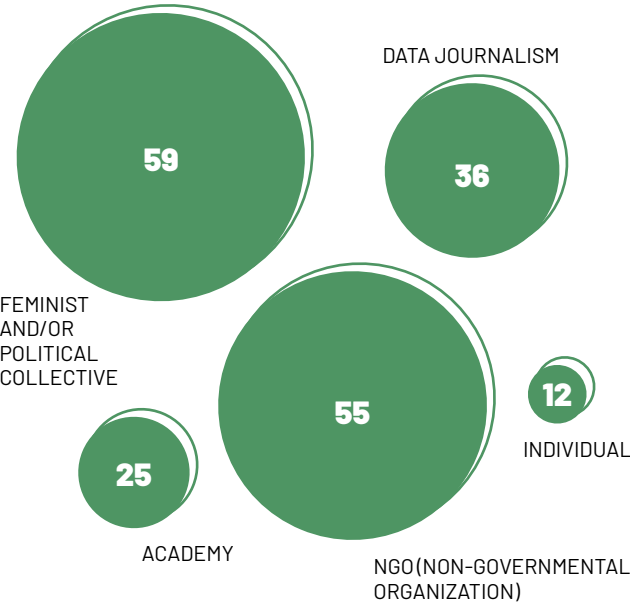
GLOBAL OVERVIEW

To understand how widespread data activism practices against femicide are, in 2019 we began cataloging projects that monitor lethal gender-related violence. Since then, we have documented more than 190 projects and we imagine that there are many more out there. The graphs below, originally published in Catherine D'Ignazio's book *Counting Femicide*, illustrate the geographic distribution and sectors of the projects we have mapped and the types of violence they monitor.

WHAT REGIONS ARE DATA ACTIVISM PROJECTS MONITORING?

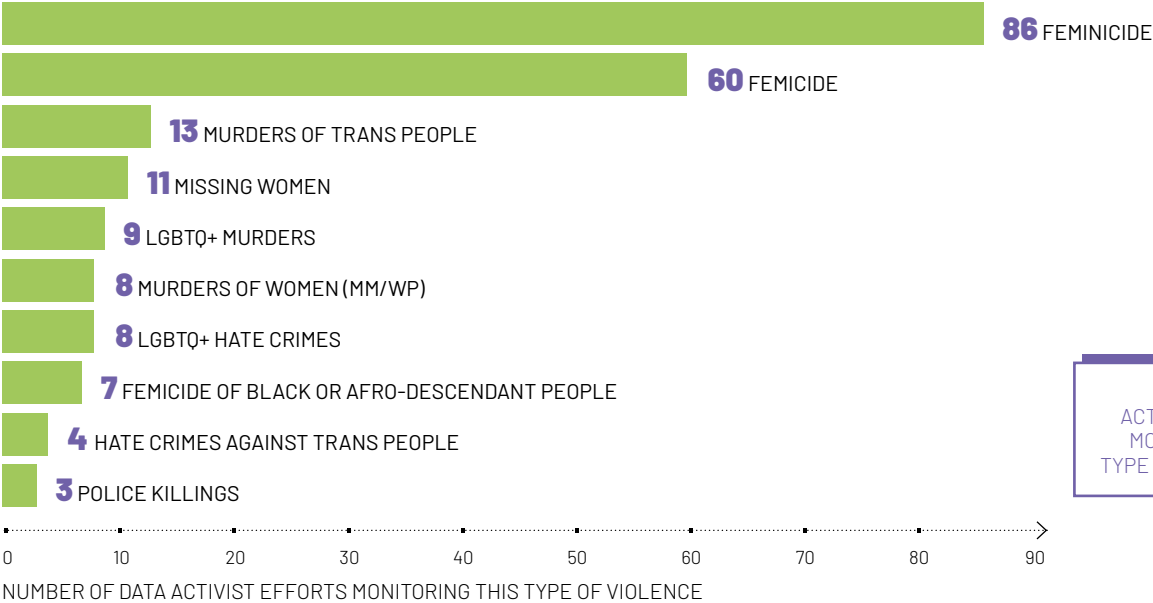


WHAT SECTOR DO DATA ACTIVISM PROJECTS COME FROM?



Source: D'Ignazio 2024, p. 78.

TYPES OF GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE MONITORED BY DATA ACTIVISTS



MANY DATA ACTIVISTS TRACK MORE THAN ONE TYPE OF VIOLENCE.

DATA ACTIVISM ON FEMINICIDE IN THE US AND CANADA

There are several organizations, collectives and activists that monitor feminicides in the US and Canada. Here, we highlight organizations and projects that collaborate with DCF and that have contributed to the development of tools in English to support the production of data on feminicide and other forms of gender-related violence:

**African American Policy Forum**
www.aapf.org/sayhername

**Sovereign Bodies Institute**
www.sovereign-bodies.org

**Black Femicide USA**
www.facebook.com/blackfemicideUS

**Women Count USA**
womenscountusa.org

COUNTING AS A POLITICAL ACT: RESEARCHING, RECORDING, REFUSING

With the aim of understanding everyday practices and challenges in producing counterdata on femicide, between June 2020 and June 2023 our team conducted qualitative interviews with participants from 41 projects, covering 18 countries, that monitor feminicides and other gender-related violence in their respective contexts.

These interviews helped us to understand both differences between the projects – for example, different organizational structures and multiple ways of understanding and categorizing feminicides – as well as their similarities. While we do not aim to homogenize or simplify what different projects do, in this section we highlight common steps that we have identified in the counterdata process of different activists: *researching, recording, refusing*⁰⁸. These steps are not linear; in practice, they become intertwined, depending on the available time and capacity of the activists.

For the activists and groups we have interviewed or collaborated with directly, counting cases of femicide is not a merely statistical or neutral act; it is a political act. “Counting” here takes on different meanings. Cases are counted because the numbers help to make the deaths of women and girls visible. But no activist or group counts cases just for the sake of counting or because they believe that numbers will solve the problem. Activists count cases to tell

and memorialize the lives of women and girls. They count to challenge hegemonic narratives about structural violence.

**“THERE IS A STORY TO TELL
BEHIND EVERY MURDER OF
A WOMAN IN PERNAMBUCO.
ONE BY ONE, WE WILL TELL
THEM ALL. WE WILL MAP
OUT WHERE THEY WERE
KILLED, THE MOTIVES BEHIND
THE CRIME, FOLLOW THE
INVESTIGATION, AND DEMAND
PUNISHMENT FOR THOSE
RESPONSIBLE.”**

Project Uma por Uma, Pernambuco, Brazil

⁰⁸ We wrote about some of these steps in the article: D'Ignazio, Catherine, et al. (2022). *Femicide and counterdata production: Activist efforts to monitor and challenge gender-related violence*. *Patterns* 3(7), 7100530. In the book *Counting Femicide*, D'Ignazio expands this analysis and develops it in greater depth, including considering what motivates activists to start producing data in the first place, a necessary and important step that D'Ignazio calls “resolving”.



RESEARCHING

SEARCHING, FINDING, VERIFYING INFORMATION ABOUT CASES OF FEMINICIDE

Activists use multiple strategies to identify cases of femicide, including:

Manual searches on platforms like Google using specific keywords.

Automated notifications via Google Alerts or the tailored email alerts platform developed by the Data Against Femicide project.

Notifications via personal networks or social media.

Official public data or other publicly available data sources and archives.

Requests for public records and access to legal proceedings.

“ THE BIGGEST PROBLEM IS THAT NEWSPAPERS ARE CARELESS IN PUBLISHING BIASED AND BAD INFORMATION.”

Cuántas Más, Bolivia

The media is one of the main sources of information on femicide cases:

Most activists use online news articles as primary or supplementary sources of information about femicide cases, but they use them cautiously and strategically.

Media sources leave a lot to be desired: they often cover cases of femicide in a biased, stigmatizing, stereotypical or sensationalist way.

There is also often a lack of contextual information about the case, especially when it involves Black, Indigenous, peripheral, poor, lesbian, transvestite or transgender women and girls.

“ THE FEMICIDES OF YOUNG INDIGENOUS WOMEN AND GIRLS ARE THE MOST INVISIBLE OF THE INVISIBLE.”

National Coordinator of Indigenous Women (CONAMI), Mexico

RECORDING

EXTRACTING INFORMATION FROM SOURCES, RECORDING THEM IN A DATABASE, SPREADSHEET OR DOCUMENT, CATEGORIZING CASES, MANAGING DATA

THE TIRELESS WORK OF “COPYING AND PASTING”:

The data recording process is generally manual and laborious: most activists copy information from newspapers or other online sources and then transfer them to Excel or Google spreadsheets, or to text documents.

The choice of working method (Word or Excel, for example) reflects the level of facility with different tools, existing workflows, and available resources.



DATA COLLECTED:

Almost all projects collect information such as the name and age of murdered women and girls. Most also record information about how the femicide occurred, the date, location, and who perpetrated it.

Other types of information collected vary according to the goals and scope of each project. For example, projects such as Néias in Brazil and Seguimiento de Casos in Puerto Rico collect data not only on the murders but also on the judicial process surrounding femicide cases.

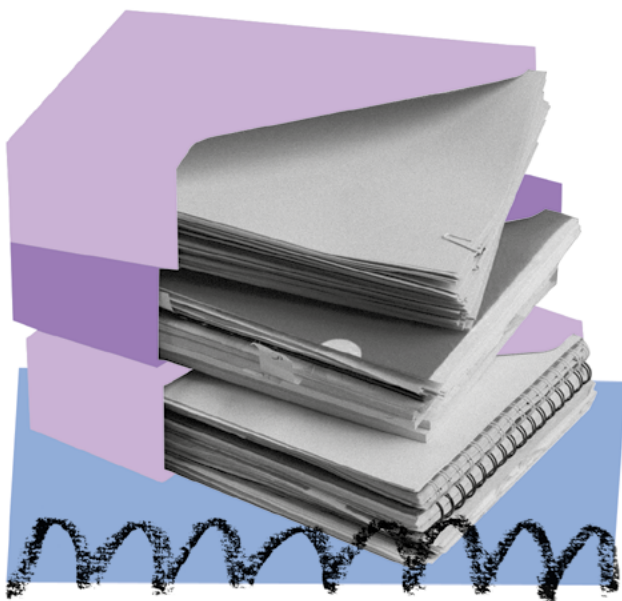
Activists leading the projects are mindful that data are not neutral; that decisions about what to collect or how to classify information are political acts. For example, Helena Suárez Val, from the project Femicidio Uruguay, intentionally named the field where she enters the name of the murdered person as “name of the woman” instead of “victim” or “name of the victim” in order to avoid essentializing the condition of victim and to reposition the person as a subject.



TYPES OF FEMINICIDE:

Some projects simply classify cases as feminicides or not, generally taking into account existing legislation and/or governmental and international categorization guidelines, such as the United Nations' *"Latin American Model Protocol for the investigation of gender-related killings of women (femicide/feminicide)"*.

Many activists have also developed their own typologies for classifying cases, involving categories such as transfeminicide, feminicide in stigmatized occupations (e.g., sex workers), attempted feminicide, feminicide related to organized crime, ecofeminicide, transnational feminicide, among others.



CARING FOR THE DATA:

Several activists expressed concerns about data privacy and ethical issues related to the publication of the counterdata they produced, such as in situations where it may pose risks to family members or people related to the murdered person.

Several activists also highlighted the importance of verifying information across different sources, double-checking data, and developing monitoring methodologies that are transparent and verifiable by other actors.

There are initiatives that aim to harmonize data on feminicide across different contexts in order to create bridges between the work of different activists and to make the phenomenon visible at a transnational scale. This is the case of the work of Mundo Sur via the Red Latinoamericana Contra la Violencia de Género. The Latin American Open Data Initiative (ILDA) has also created a standard and protocol for data production about feminicide for government actors that may serve as inspiration for activists.



REFUSING

USING COUNTERDATA TO CONFRONT, COUNTER, AND REJECT FEMINICIDE VIOLENCE

Activists mobilize data in a variety of ways and for a variety of purposes. Here, we highlight five strategies: repair, remember, reframe, reform, and revolt. Not all groups and activists employ all of these strategies, but nearly all engage in one or more of them.

Repair: providing support or services to communities and families

“*There was a classic case in Limoeiro, where the husband killed his wife and then killed himself. He left three children orphaned. The children were not receiving any support from the city, nothing, zero. So I called the [public agency] and said, ‘Are you offering psychological support? How are you handling this?’ They weren’t offering anything. ... Then the next week they did a bunch of things for the family. ... So, in our investigative work and reporting we sort of tried to create pressure: ‘What is being done? Was [the investigation] interrupted? Why was it interrupted?’ We did the same thing at all levels, the Public Prosecutor’s Office, the Justice Department, and the police.”*

Uma por Uma, Pernambuco, Brazil

Remember: memorializing the individual and collective lives lost to structural violence

“*And I felt like [recording this information] was a way to have a memory of these women, which is really important. It was a way to show that they were more than just statistics on a page.”*

Women Count USA, United States

Reframe: developing counter-narratives about femicide, whether by honoring the lives of murdered women or by challenging media representations and official statistics

“*The Observatory is also about producing other narratives about the cases, both in the public debate, in the tension with the Judiciary, as well as with the local media, with journalists. We have been talking about the importance of cultivating ways to remember these cases, these women, and their stories in the city. But in addition to producing these forms of remembrance, this is about creating other possibilities for understanding, locating and reporting on these cases.”*

Néias - Observatório de Femicídios de Londrina, Paraná, Brazil

Reform: seeking changes in institutional practices, public policies and legislation through political advocacy with public actors

Revolt: supporting political mobilization and collective action in public spaces through the use of data in protests, artistic interventions, campaigns, etc

“ We did a lot of advocacy work, publishing the data, and then we started to notice the discrepancy with the recognition of femicide by the Security Department, right? Because there were cases that appeared in the media, and then we would check the Department's data, they had been classified as intentional homicides. We started to question the Department from that point on.”

Fórum Cearense de Mulheres, Ceará, Brazil

“ The information generated by the observatory is useful, it helps to make the numbers visible in public demonstrations or to bring them to light in conversations with the government. In short, it serves as an element of argumentation, of protest, of demand. This is also important.”

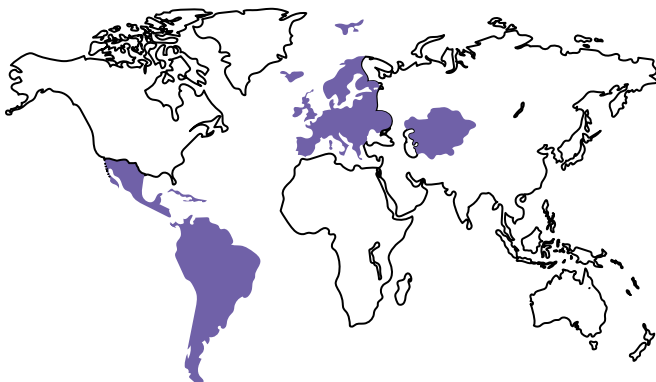
Anonymous organization, Mexico



GLOBAL SURVEY: DATA ACTIVISM AGAINST FEMINICIDE

Results of a global survey on data activism against femicide conducted by the Data Against Femicide project through the Data + Feminism Lab (MIT) between **November 2023 and March 2024**.

WHO PARTICIPATED IN THE SURVEY?



38

ACTIVISTS/GROUPS INVOLVED
IN PROJECTS IN LATIN
AMERICA, EUROPE AND
CENTRAL ASIA RESPONDED TO
THE QUESTIONNAIRE IN FULL.

THE OLDEST PROJECT
IS 28 YEARS OLD AND
THE NEWEST STARTED
IN 2023.

WHY PRODUCE DATA?

Addressing gaps in existing data from government agencies or other civil society organizations was one of the most common motivations for groups and activists to start producing their own data about femicides.

“As there is no official data on femicide in Serbia, AWC decided to create its own database on femicide, collected through media reports and citizens.”

Autonomous Women's Center (AWC), Serbia

DATA IS USED STRATEGICALLY, OFTEN TO CHALLENGE GOVERNMENT INACTION.

“We use data as a form of political advocacy to demand fair sanctions and prevent impunity, to demand public policies from the State that guarantee the rights of the LGBTIQ+ community and provide resources for violence prevention programs.”

Trans Siempre Amigas, Dominican Republic

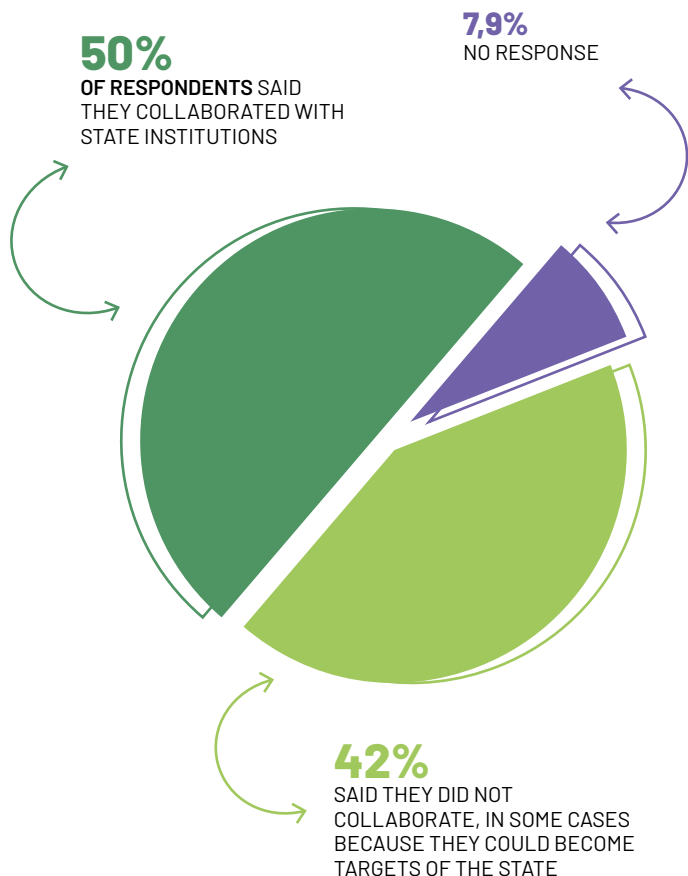
“The new Belgian law on femicide is a direct result of the work carried out by StopFemicide Belgium.”

StopFemicide, Belgium

“Early findings in 2008 showed that a murder of a trans person was reported every three days, while in 2021 this number has increased to more than one murder of a trans person per day. Documenting anti-trans violence is crucial and we use our data to call on activists, policymakers, legislators and donors to listen to our community and take urgent action to protect the lives of trans and gender diverse people as our shared responsibility.”

Transgender Europe, TGEU

ACTIVISTS AND GROUPS HAVE COMPLEX RELATIONSHIPS WITH THE STATE, INVOLVING BOTH CONTESTATION AND COLLABORATION:



“ We are criminalized by these institutions. However, we publish the information on our social networks and these institutions read it, but nothing official because otherwise it would be a way for them to give us recognition.”

YoSiTeCreo, Cuba

IN THE EXPERIENCE OF SEVERAL GROUPS, MORE QUALIFIED MEDIA COVERAGE WOULD FACILITATE THE SEARCH FOR INFORMATION AND THE PRODUCTION OF DATA AGAINST FEMINICIDE.

5 MAIN CHALLENGES WHEN SEEKING INFORMATION ABOUT FEMINICIDE:

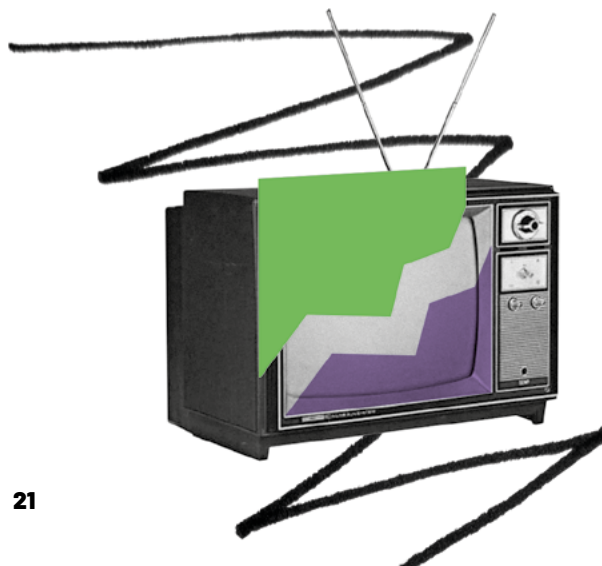
Media coverage is stigmatizing, misogynist, racist or transphobic

There is underreporting or lack of media coverage of specific types of femicide (e.g. trans, Indigenous, racialized, low-income, sex workers)

Official data on femicide are not published or accessible

Deaths are misclassified in government data

There is less media coverage of rural or remote areas



GEOGRAPHIES OF DATA PRODUCTION AGAINST FEMINICIDE

As we documented data activism practices on femicide, we observed that social and spatial factors influence the availability of information on different cases and activists' own monitoring and counterdata production strategies⁰⁹.

GEOGRAPHIES OF MISSING DATA

In the experience of several activists, there are striking transnational patterns in relation to *where* femicides are or are not reported and recorded in the media or in official data.

The spatial reach of state institutions and the media is limited in terms of presence, infrastructure and resources.

Femicides in more connected regions such as capital cities tend to be more documented than in rural or more remote regions. In the United States, the *Black Femicide US* project noted that rural communities preferred not to engage with institutions from outside their communities.

Femicides in peripheral or vulnerable urban areas also tend to be less reported, especially when the cases involve women from marginalized groups in terms of race, ethnicity, class or gender identity.

Organized crime, including gangs, armed men and paramilitary activity, has also been identified as a factor that not only leads to femicides but also makes it more difficult to obtain information about cases in some contexts.

“The femicides that occur in the center of the country are well documented. But those that occur in the periphery are not.”

Red Feminista Antimilitarista, Colombia

“Costa Rica is very small, but even so, the road connections and everything else are not easy. Going from San José to Puntarenas is easy, it's quick (...) but from Puntarenas you have to take a boat. (...) I mean, in total it took about five hours to get to this girl's family and be able to do my interviews. And then [we] realize that in these areas the State doesn't exist. These have also been some of my results when analyzing femicides outside of urban areas, because people don't have access.”

Recordar-LAS, Costa Rica

⁰⁹ D'Ignazio, Catherine, Cruxên, Isadora, Martínez Cuba, Angeles, Suárez Val, Helena, García-Montes, Mariel, Doğan, Amelia L., and Ansari, Natasha. (2024). *Geographies of missing data: Spatializing counterdata production against femicide*. Environment and Planning D: Society and Space, online first.

SPATIAL STRATEGIES FOR COUNTERDATA PRODUCTION

Activists use a variety of spatial strategies to document cases that occur in spaces or involve bodies and identities that are often made invisible. From the local to the international level, activists make the sites and contexts of violence visible, create coalitions to monitor femicide in their territories, use their databases as sacred sites of remembrance and memory, and build transnational networks of solidarity and knowledge sharing. We organize these strategies into four categories: reach, emplace, reclaim, and “cruzar/crossing.”

Emplace: collecting, producing, and visualizing geographic data in order to contextualize and situate cases of femicide in space.

>> Several activists document the location or place of death in order to understand the context of the case – which can be important for classifying a murder as a femicide – or also to problematize narratives about where feminicides happen (for example, the idea of the home as a safe space).

>> Activists from Letra Ese, Mexico, have identified a high incidence of bodies of trans women and lesbians that are found in open public spaces, such as rivers, water channels, roads or even cemeteries and, in the case of sex workers, near their workplaces.

>> Some projects use maps as a way to visualize cases geographically, but activists recognize the tensions inherent in this strategy, as the visibility granted to specific locations through data can make the bodies that inhabit these spaces more susceptible to stigma and oppression.

Reclaim: transforming data into public spatial interventions and physical installations that demand justice and center remembrance of women’s and girls’ lives. A significant proportion of activists also see the database itself as a place to remember, bear witness and care for people, even after their death.

Reach: amplifying the ability to identify cases and access information about different locations and regions, thus reaching into the monitored territories via:

>> Organizational decentralization and creation of local networks and coalitions.

>> Use of social media or hyper-local media sources such as small newspapers, blogs and radio stations.

“That is why I think what I mentioned at the beginning about [the need] to ‘federalise’ and to have colleagues in the localities who can work on this is so important, because when we receive a case that did not reach us virtually, in the alert system, it is our colleagues in the provinces or localities who can carry out an investigation on site, to tell us what is happening in relation to the context of gender violence in the provinces or localities.”

Ahora que si nos ven, Argentina

Cruzar/Crossing: counterdata strategies often involve building connections across territories, practices, and experiences to illuminate patterns of violence across scales (local, national, regional) or develop bonds of solidarity. One of the objectives of Data Against Femicide is to promote this crossing of boundaries. Some examples of networks that cross territories include:

>> Red Latinoamericana contra la Violencia de Género, organized by Mundo Sur

>> Red Regional de Información sobre Violencias LGBT, organized by Letra Ese and Colombia Diversa

>> Levante Feminista Contra o Femicídio, Lesbocídio e Transfeminicídio, Brazil

>> Red Chilena Contra la Violencia hacia las Mujeres

EMOTIONAL LABOR AND THE NEED FOR SELF-CARE

Producing counterdata on femicide is a labor of care and a form of emotional labor. Frequently reading stories of violence and recording each case not only demands time and manual labor, but is also mentally and emotionally exhausting. In some cases, it can also cause secondary trauma, as individuals emotionally relive the pain and suffering of the victims through their stories.

Many activists we interacted with or collaborated with reported moments of exhaustion, frustration, and tears while carrying out this work. At the same time, they shared strategies for self-care and collective care that allow them to continue the work over time and create spaces for sharing and solidarity. Inspired by an essay written by Suárez Val, Martínez Cuba and D'Ignazio¹⁰, we summarize some of these strategies here:

DAILY MAINTENANCE

Some daily maintenance tactics to alleviate emotional labor include taking breaks and setting boundaries for casework, and working at one's own pace. Additionally, automating some processes or learning new technologies or techniques can help minimize manual and emotional labor.

“In fact [automating] would greatly reduce the work. [...] A preliminary database that is already at least moderately refined [...] allows us to focus [...] on establishing the traceability of each story, of each case. [...] And not so much on the emotional exhaustion of seeing everything else.”

Cuántas Más, Bolivia

¹⁰ Suárez Val, Helena, Martínez Cuba, Angeles, and D'Ignazio, Catherine. (2022, June 13). Femicide data, emotional labor, and self-care. *Society for Social Studies of Science*. Backchannels 4S Blog. <https://medium.com/@kanarinka/feminine-data-emotional-work-and-self-care-dc61c6e8553c>

Limit frequency of data collection

Taking breaks and setting boundaries

Focus on technical learning regarding data logging

Automate aspects of data recording

MANAGING THE RELATIONSHIP WITH THE DATA

Other tactics are related to managing the emotional relationship that activists build with femicide data, such as distancing themselves from certain aspects of the violence or avoiding recording certain fields to reduce the emotional impact. Some activists noted that they channel their anger into producing counter-data and concrete actions. Many also expressed that their commitment to the work gives them the strength to monitor and overcome emotional trauma.

“There’s always going to be a case that presents a challenge, that makes you stop and say, ‘I don’t know if I want to do this tomorrow.’ But then you get up and you do it tomorrow because [...] if you’re not angry, you’re not paying attention. So I just need to channel the anger for the greater good, so to speak.”

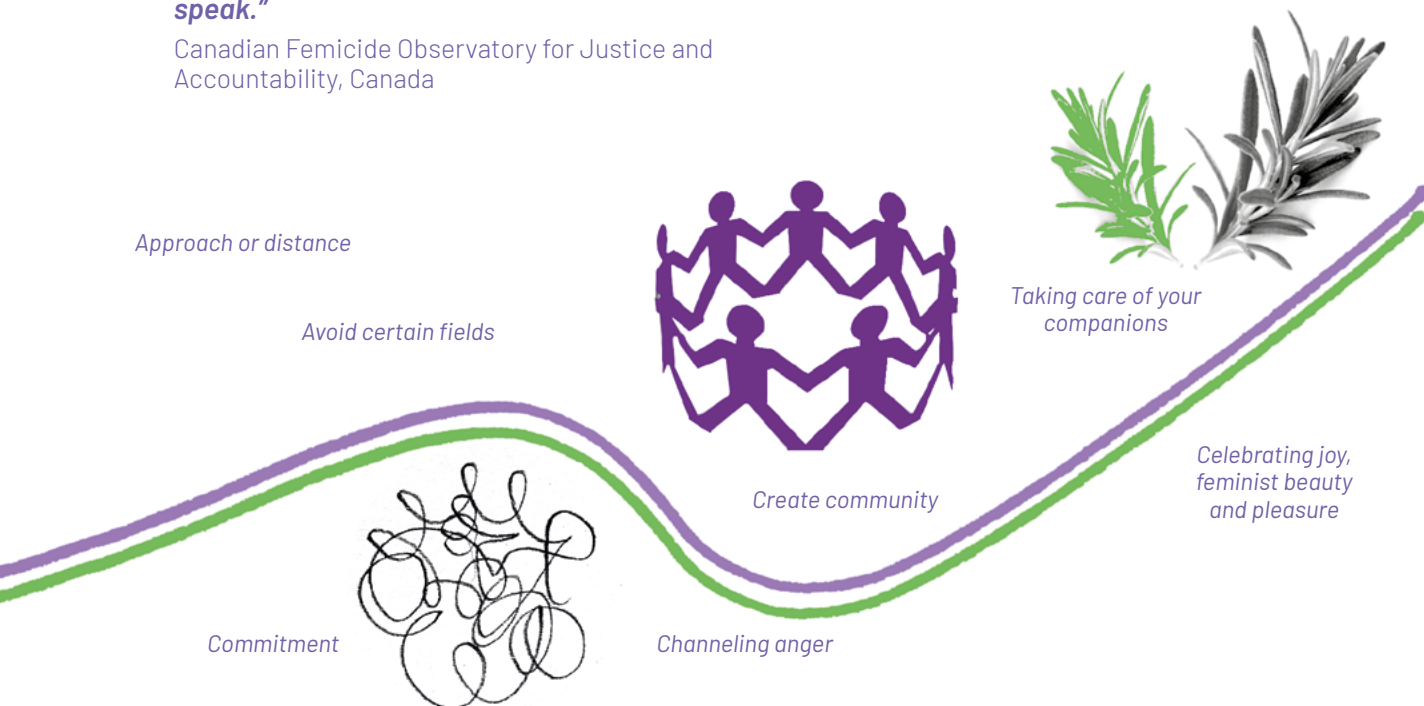
Canadian Femicide Observatory for Justice and Accountability, Canada

ETHICAL-POLITICAL PRACTICES OF FEMINISM

Other tactics relate to the ethical-political practice of feminism, with mutual emotional check-ins between peers and contention and collective support spaces to ease the burden of monitoring. Individual activists also use collective spaces as a form of self-care. Groups like the Red Feminista Antimilitarista highlighted the beauty of creating a feminist community to “not only think about death, but also about collective construction

“We have many meetings to talk about pleasure, orgasms, happiness, as well as abandoning necrophilia a little and being able to collectively build feminist beauty.”

Red Feminista Antimilitarista, Colombia



CO-DEVELOPING ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI) TOOLS TO SUPPORT DATA ACTIVISM

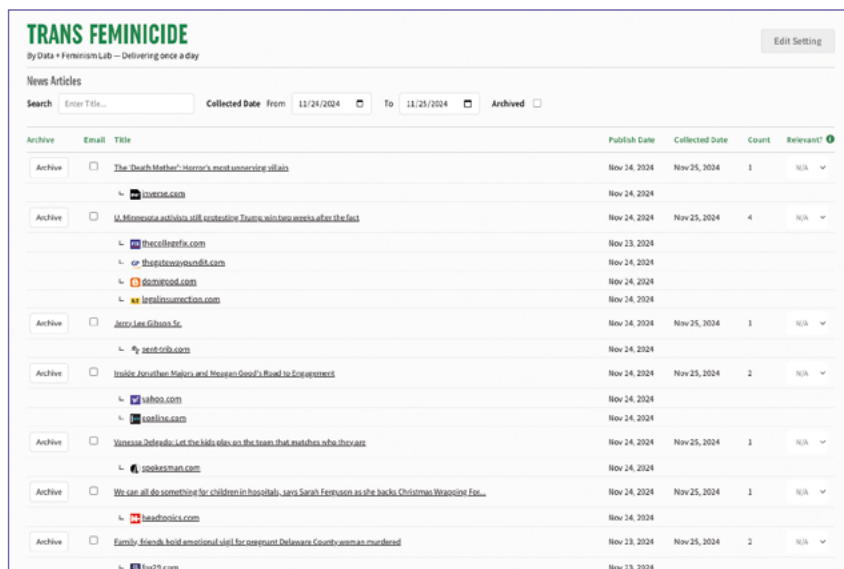
The socioeconomic and political importance of data and artificial intelligence (AI) is currently growing, which raises concerns about data extraction, the reproduction of inequalities, and the surveillance of vulnerable populations and minority groups.

In contrast to dominant – and often corporate – perspectives on data use and AI development, the Data Against Feminicide project seeks to promote an approach to data and AI ethics inspired by feminist, non-extractivist principles. This approach (1) understands that structural inequalities produce missing and flawed data, and (2) aims to advance alternative practices for data production and for the development of technological tools through participatory and plural methodologies.

In this spirit, since 2020 we have been collaborating with activists from different regions in the Americas to co-design and develop two tools to support the production of data on feminicides: a custom AI-supported email alert platform and a data highlighter.

EMAIL ALERTS

The email alert platform aims to facilitate the work of identifying news stories that concern feminicide cases, a key part of the researching process of many activists. As noted earlier, the majority of projects use online news and media articles to monitor feminicide cases, which means activists have to read a lot of violent – and often not directly relevant – content to identify cases in their contexts. Seeking to facilitate (rather than replace) this labor, the platform we have co-developed uses a form of AI called machine learning to detect and compile news articles that are likely to refer to a feminicide and send them to activists via email.



TRANS FEMINICIDE
By Data + FeminismLab — Delivering once a day

News Articles

Search Collected Date From 11/24/2024 To 11/25/2024 Archived ☐

Archive	Email	Title	Publish Date	Collected Date	Count	Relevant?
☐	☐	The "Death Mother" terror's most terrifying villain	Nov 14, 2024	Nov 25, 2024	1	N/A
		↳ theatlantic.com	Nov 24, 2024			
☐	☐	U.S. Minnesota activists still celebrate Taylor Swift's new album after the fest	Nov 24, 2024	Nov 25, 2024	4	N/A
		↳ thecellonline.com	Nov 23, 2024			
		↳ theatlantic.com	Nov 24, 2024			
		↳ theatlantic.com	Nov 24, 2024			
		↳ theatlantic.com	Nov 24, 2024			
☐	☐	Jerry Lee Gibson Sr.	Nov 14, 2024	Nov 25, 2024	1	N/A
		↳ theatlantic.com	Nov 24, 2024			
☐	☐	Inside Jonathan Meier and Neamen Gopal's Road to Engagement	Nov 24, 2024	Nov 25, 2024	2	N/A
		↳ yahoo.com	Nov 24, 2024			
		↳ theatlantic.com	Nov 24, 2024			
☐	☐	Venezuela's Didelis: Let the kids play on the team that matches who they want	Nov 24, 2024	Nov 25, 2024	1	N/A
		↳ theatlantic.com	Nov 24, 2024			
☐	☐	We can all do something for children in hospitals - says Sarah Freeman as she backs Christmas Magazine For...	Nov 24, 2024	Nov 25, 2024	1	N/A
		↳ theadvocate.com	Nov 14, 2024			
☐	☐	Family friends hold emotional vigil for deceased Delaware County woman murdered	Nov 13, 2024	Nov 25, 2024	2	N/A
		↳ fox23.com	Nov 23, 2024			

PLATFORM USAGE DATA:

150+ USERS;

AT LEAST
65 DISTINCT PROJECTS
ACTIVE ON THE PLATFORM;

PROJECTS ARE
DISTRIBUTED ACROSS
14 COUNTRIES;

BRAZIL HAS THE
LARGEST NUMBER OF
PROJECTS WITH 19.

→ **How does it work?**

Through the email alerts platform, activists can create a project to monitor news articles related to femicide in specific geographies, such as at the state or national level, and define keywords of interest.

The platform's underlying system selects media articles from extensive news catalogs (such as Media Cloud, one of our partners) through two main mechanisms. First, it uses keywords selected by activists to perform an initial search for relevant news articles in the media catalogs. The initial results are then filtered again by a machine learning model that was trained to identify news stories that are most likely to be about a case of femicide. The news stories surfaced by the machine learning model are then compiled and sent to activists via email alerts or can be accessed directly on the web platform, as shown in the image above.

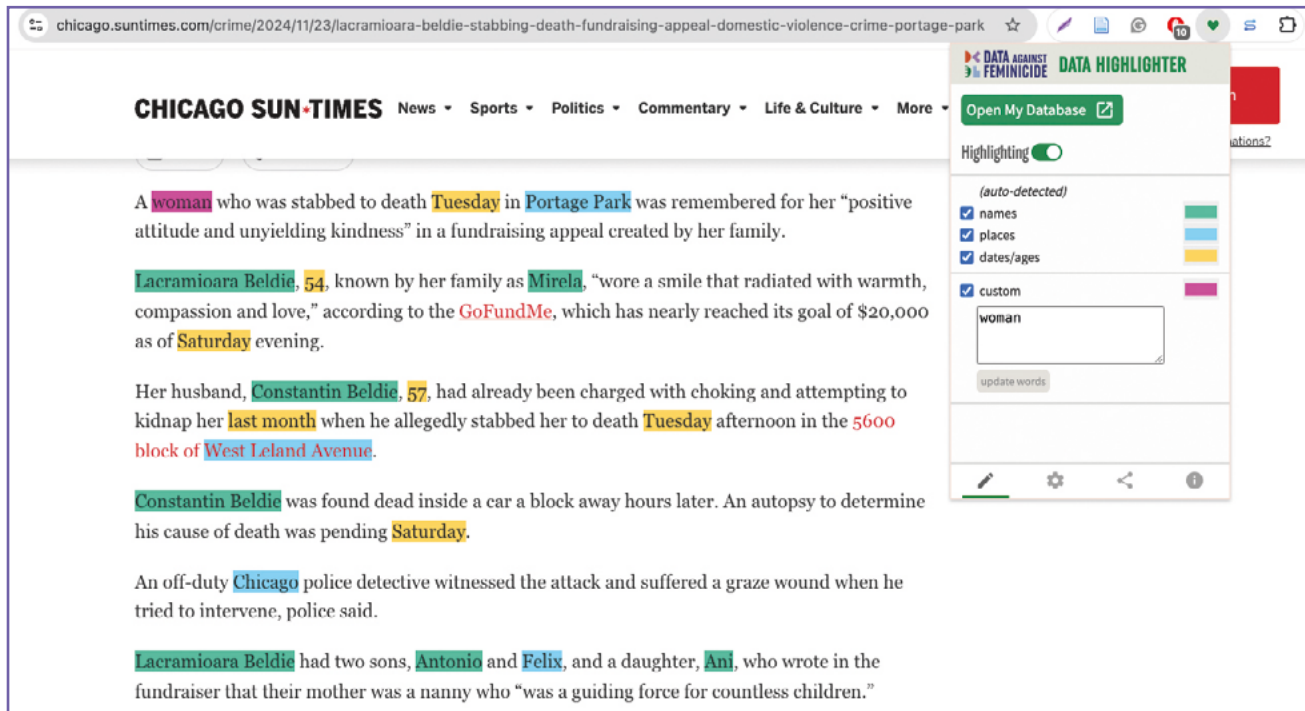
The system is currently available in Spanish, English and Portuguese, and we are developing versions in Korean and Swahili. News catalogs are organized geographically and it is possible to add more relevant media sources.

Our machine learning models were trained in collaboration with many activist groups through participatory news classification and tool evaluation processes. At the end of this report, we acknowledge all of the activists and groups who contributed to this process thus far.

DATA HIGHLIGHTER

The data highlighter is an extension for the Chrome browser that highlights keywords in news articles and helps to locate relevant information about cases of femicide, as illustrated in the image below.

Through the browser extension, a user can add their own keywords to highlight, send relevant media articles to an email, and open a Google spreadsheet to quickly copy data into it.



TUTORIALS

You can find tutorials on how to use the tools here:
https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1RInviy_-8Inch-BLxGUlixJ5Dk_FKDBaT

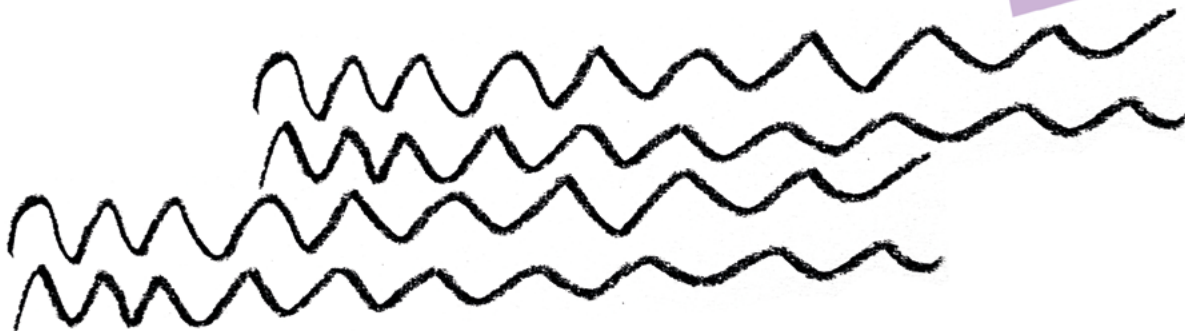
CHALLENGES AND REFLECTIONS

The tools we have developed collaboratively are not perfect, nor are they finished products; they are tools and systems under construction. In dialogue with activists and collaborators, we continue to learn and reflect on their limits and possibilities for improvement. Here, we highlight some questions and challenges that emerged from our research and participatory processes with activists:

How to develop computational tools for politically contested concepts?

Activists work with different understandings of femicide, in different languages, and in different contexts and geographical scales, including in terms of media coverage.

These differences are not easy to reconcile and challenge the development of plural technical systems for identifying femicides from news reports. This is why the email platform, for example, may work better in some contexts than in others and was developed to complement and not replace the work of activists, who are experts in the contexts they monitor.



How to improve the ability of AI models to detect intersectional forms of femicide?

Data feminism involves both looking closely at how existing data and technical systems reproduce structural inequalities in society, and seeking to develop technological tools that work for diverse groups and communities, not simply for an average or majority.

When we launched the email platform for testing, feedback and recommendations from project contributors indicated that the machine learning model worked relatively well for projects that track all types of femicide (e.g., all women and girls killed in a region), but was less effective for activists and groups monitoring intersectional forms of lethal violence, such as femicides of Indigenous women and girls, femicides of trans women, or police killings of Black women. There are several reasons for this, including the racial and class bias of media coverage, which tends to focus more on femicides of white, middle- or upper-class women.

To address these biases, as we discussed in a specific study led by Harini Suresh and Raj Movva¹¹, we learned that it is necessary to develop contextual AI models, which are built iteratively and from an intersectional perspective.

How to maintain tools and collaborations over time?

Another significant challenge has to do with the continuity of the tools and collaborative relationships that support their development over time. Today, the email platform, for example, is used by more than 150 people in several countries. We work daily to deal with failures or interruptions and communicate with users about the functioning of the platform.

Maintaining tools that are useful in the real world is a challenge for academic projects that are not market-oriented and have limited resources. Funding agencies tend to favor innovation over maintenance. We do not yet have answers on how to address these institutional barriers, but we continue to reflect on how to maintain the tools and relationships we have built with respect and care.

In addition to the use of the tools, the long-term relationships and collaborations we have developed with different project participants is one of our greatest sources of pride.

¹¹ Suresh, Harini, Movva, Rajiv, Dogan, Amelia L., Bhargava, Rahul, Cru- xen, Isadora, Martínez Cuba, Angeles, Taurino, Giulia, So, Wonyoung e D'Ignazio, Catherine. (2022). *Towards Intersectional Feminist and Participatory ML: A Case Study in Supporting Femicide Counterdata Col- lection*. 2022 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Trans- parency, 667–678. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3531146.3533132>

BUILDING A COMMUNITY

One of the goals of our project is to create spaces that support the development of a community of practice around data activism against feminicide. A community of practice is a group of people who share interests and deepen their knowledge and experience in the field through ongoing interaction that strengthens their relationships.¹² We consider our community of practice to be all those people and groups who work or want to work with feminicide data.

In order to collectively build this community, **since 2020 we have held annual events in November to mark the International Day for the Elimination of Violence against Women.** The events are held in Spanish, English and Portuguese and bring together people from diverse contexts and backgrounds, including activists, civil society organizations, public officials, academics and journalists. The events follow different formats, such as discussion groups, workshops and interactive sessions. All recordings are available on this channel: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7JcJDdnVf9o&list=PLFAK5YaaCeF50-hEPPxK_6hEuDLYDxINfM.

¹² Wenger, Etienne. (2006). *Communities of practice: A brief introduction*. Disponible en: <https://www.wenger-trayner.com/introduction-to-communities-of-practice/>

2020

DATA AGAINST FEMINICIDE

What are different ways to work with data about feminicide? How can this data be used? How does it impact those who produce it?

2021

TECHNOLOGY IN ACTION

How can algorithms help us to confront feminicide?

2022

VISIBILITIES: ART AND DATA ON FEMINICIDE

How can we communicate and disseminate data on feminicide? How can artistic practices help to make gender-related violence visible?

2023

STRATEGIC DATAFICATION

What are the strategic uses and limitations of data in combating feminicide? What kinds of data and how much data do we need to take action?

2024

MEDIA AGAINST FEMINICIDE: NARRATIVES, CHALLENGES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

What is the role of the news media in the struggle against feminicide? What are the recommended practices for improving media coverage and how can we facilitate their adoption?

ABOUT **DCF**

HOW TO JOIN OUR DATA ACTIVISM COMMUNITY?

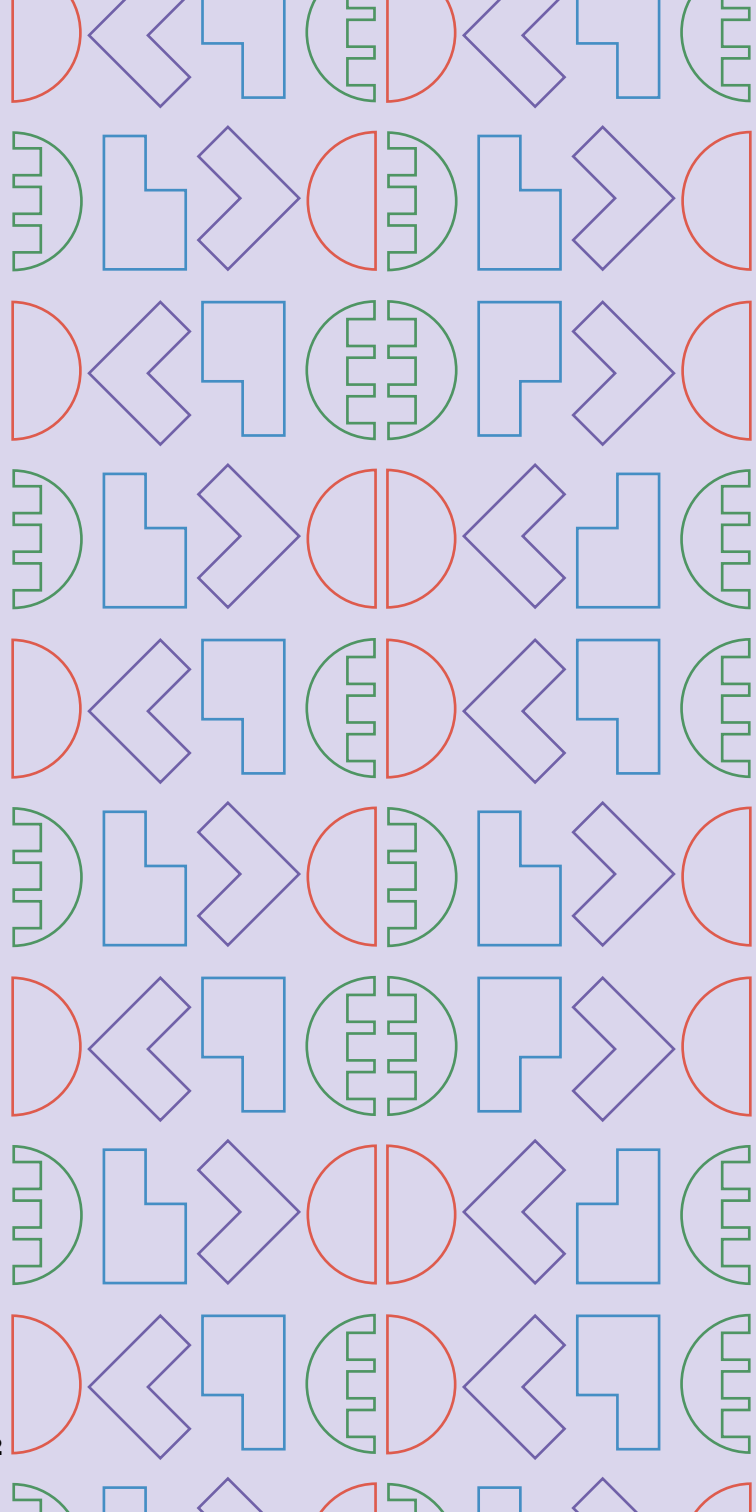
To join the **Data Against Femicide** community, simply send an email to **datoscontrafeminicidio@gmail.com** indicating your interest and register for the project's newsletter at the following link:

<https://datoscontrafeminicidio.net/en/home-2/>

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION:

DCF PUBLICATIONS

<https://datoscontrafeminicidio.net/publicaciones/>



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ACTIVISTS SPEAK OUT



**"THE PATH BEGINS
WITH BEING PART OF
A COLLECTIVE AND
UNDERSTANDING THAT
[FEMINICIDE] IS A SHARED
ISSUE AMONG US ALL."**



**"WE CAN NEVER GIVE
UP. [MONITORING
FEMINICIDE] IS A
PROCESS THAT
PRODUCES SUFFERING,
SO WE NEED A
POLITICS OF CARE AND
SELF-CARE."**

Messages written by collaborators of the DCF project in Brazil in 2022 for other "companheiras", activists and groups that produce or want to produce data against femicide.



**"LET US NOT LOSE HOPE
NOR TURN OUR FINDINGS
INTO NUMBERS. THE
VICTIMS OF FEMINICIDE
ARE PEOPLE, SUBJECTS
WITH RIGHTS."**

**"ALWAYS SEEK
TO 'TRANSLATE'
DATA FOR A WIDER
AUDIENCE."**

**"[DATA COLLECTION] IS A
TOUGH TASK, BUT A VERY
NECESSARY ONE. WE NEED
TO CONTINUE THIS STRUGGLE
SO THAT WE HAVE RELIABLE
DATA AND INFORMATION [TO
BRING] MEMORY AND JUSTICE
TO ALL WOMEN."**



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Production



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